

Nook 3G to be phased out

Barnes and Noble will discontinue Nook 3G due to the dwindling supply

Airtel launches 3G services

After waiting for many months, Airtel has finally launched its 3G services with a data plan of ₹650 for 1.25 GB/month



ECCE Robot

morph material which consist of plastic pellets, tendons are made of kite line, elastic material of a muscle is provided by a shock cord and finally the muscles are actuated by screw-driver motors.

Modular Robots

Students from University of Pennsylvania's Modular Robotics lab showcased the Connector Kinetic Robot (CKBot) which at first glance resembles a centipede. Each modular robot is a small and can move along one rotational degree. Many such units can be connected to each other to scale the robot making it more robust at the same time. This robot can be attached to various other modules like a gripper

module, to IR proximity sensors, camera modules to apply it in various use case scenarios. We were informed by the students that it was a lab project and they saw its future applications in areas like robotic arm, search and rescue, space exploration, anywhere you have multiple applications. It is a scalable solution where you can keep adding on modules depending on the nature of use and a single structure can serve more than one purpose.

Touch the Invisibles

With touchscreens becoming ubiquitous these days, how cool would it be if you were able to feel what you touch. Haptic feedback technology does that to an extent, but it cannot give different feedbacks based on the surface. Scientists from Osaka University and NTT Communication Science lab have developed a nail mounted tactile interface. A vibrator which is voice coil, is attached to the users nail and as you move your finger along the display and come across any obstacle, a vibration can be felt. So for instance if you move your finger with

the vibrator along a patterned surface on the screen, you will feel some smooth vibrations on your nail and when you move your finger along say a pebbled road, the vibrations will be stronger. Using this interface, any kind of visual information can be presented with real time tactile feedback. This can be helpful for visually impaired people in surface recognition.

Research from IIT

IIT itself has so many department and the Techfest provides a perfect platform to showcase some cutting edge research happening in these temples of higher education. Each department had a stall demonstrating their research projects.

Industrial Design Centre exhibits

This is one stall that drew a lot of oohs and aahs from the



The amphibious bike concept displayed at the IDC stall

crowd. Well why wouldn't it. There were some really crazy design models on display here like the amphibious bike, the bicycle that can be rode while you are in a sleeping position, a Devanagari script app for typing in regional language on a touchscreen mobile phone.

Robotic Art

Imagine an exhibition where the artist is a robot. Don't

fall off your chair, as this is exactly what we were greeted to on the Robotics Action Painter(RAP) stall. The ISU robot developed by artist and artificial intelligence enthusiast, Leonel Moura, uses artificial intelligence algorithms to paint and determine when the work is done. It also signs off after its artwork is complete. The robot starts randomly and gradually evolves to generate colour clusters.

It was at work when we visited the stall and the artwork involved writing alphabets one of top of the other across a large chart paper. What fascinates you is the fact that the robot is not programmed to sketch, but does so of its own volition. It was eerie at the same time.

Fun at the Techfest

IIT Techfest is not just about academics. Fun element is paid

special attention to as well. Performance artists from around the world showcased their goods here. BMX stunt biking by an India stunt biking group called Team Gear grabbed a lot of eyeballs. From Belgium descended a group called the Double Dutch Force whose dance per-

formance with two ropes left us impressed. Yeah, this is the same group who has performed those insane skipping-rope stunts in the song 'Rise Up' by house artist Yves Larock. If you haven't seen that video already, please do.

That's it for this year's coverage. Do not forget to catch more videos from the Techfest in Digit TV in the Digit Omega DVD. 

